

Thick forests like the one in this 15th-century painting by Italian artist Paolo Uccello are returning to Europe, where they have grown by 42 million acres (17 million ha) since the 1990s.

Deteriorating soil

Topsoil is perhaps one of the world's most undervalued resources. This vast ecosystem, composed of animals, microbes, plant roots, and minerals, is a complex and delicate structure that is slow to form and easily lost. The World Wildlife Fund estimates that half of the world's topsoil has been eroded by wind and rain in the last 150 years. Particles then collect in streams and rivers, clogging them with sediment. Soil loss occurs due to overgrazing, removal of hedges, and use of agrochemicals that affect the soil structure. Measures such as resting the soil, terracing, dams, and strategic planting can help. In the village of Aamdanda in Nepal, for example, steep-sided slopes are stabilized with broom grass. The plant binds the soil; it is also a fodder crop and is used to make brooms, which the villagers sell.

Water pressures

Clean drinking water is a limited resource. Water covers around 75 percent of Earth's surface, but 97.5 percent of it is salt water. Of the remaining 2.5 percent, most is locked away in glaciers or in deep underground aquifers.